

Background

- Specialty pharmacy clinical programs provide comprehensive, patient-centered management for complex disease states that result in improved patient care during their treatment journey.
- While clinicians, including pharmacists and nurses, support patients with education and routine check-ins, licensed social workers (LSW) provide a unique skill set for addressing social determinants of health (SDOH) that may have a significant impact on both patients and caregivers.
- LSWs may have more opportunities for contact with patients and are able to uncover health system related and psychosocial barriers to adherence.¹
- LSWs contribute to cost savings by identifying and addressing social determinants of health that may act as barriers to care; LSW-led interventions contribute to reduced symptom burden, fewer emergency department visits and reduced hospital readmissions.^{2,5}
- In ambulatory and institutional settings, the addition of an LSW can lead to improved patient quality of life, cost-savings, and increased symptom-free days, but these outcomes have not been examined in the context of a specialty pharmacy.^{2,3}
- In mid-2022, CenterWell Specialty Pharmacy (CWSP) hired an LSW and developed internal referral program for patients enrolled in CWSP patient management program with identified need.

Objectives

- Quantify LSW CenterWell Specialty Pharmacy program referrals.
- Identify groups with high engagement with LSW and highlight areas of future research to improve patient outcomes.

Methods

- Retrospective evaluation of patients referred to CWSP LSW by clinicians from January 2024 to December 2024. Statistical analyses included descriptive statistics of collected data.
- The LSW conducted outbound calls to assist patients based on identified need, documenting each case as successful outreach, failed outreach, or unable to contact. This evaluation focused solely on successful outreach cases.
- Reasons for referral and the disease states managed by CWSP were recorded, with each case potentially having multiple referral reasons.
- Referral reasons were classified by common SDOH domains supported by the LSW.

Results

Figure 1. Specialty Pharmacy Disease States Among Patients Referred for Social Work Support

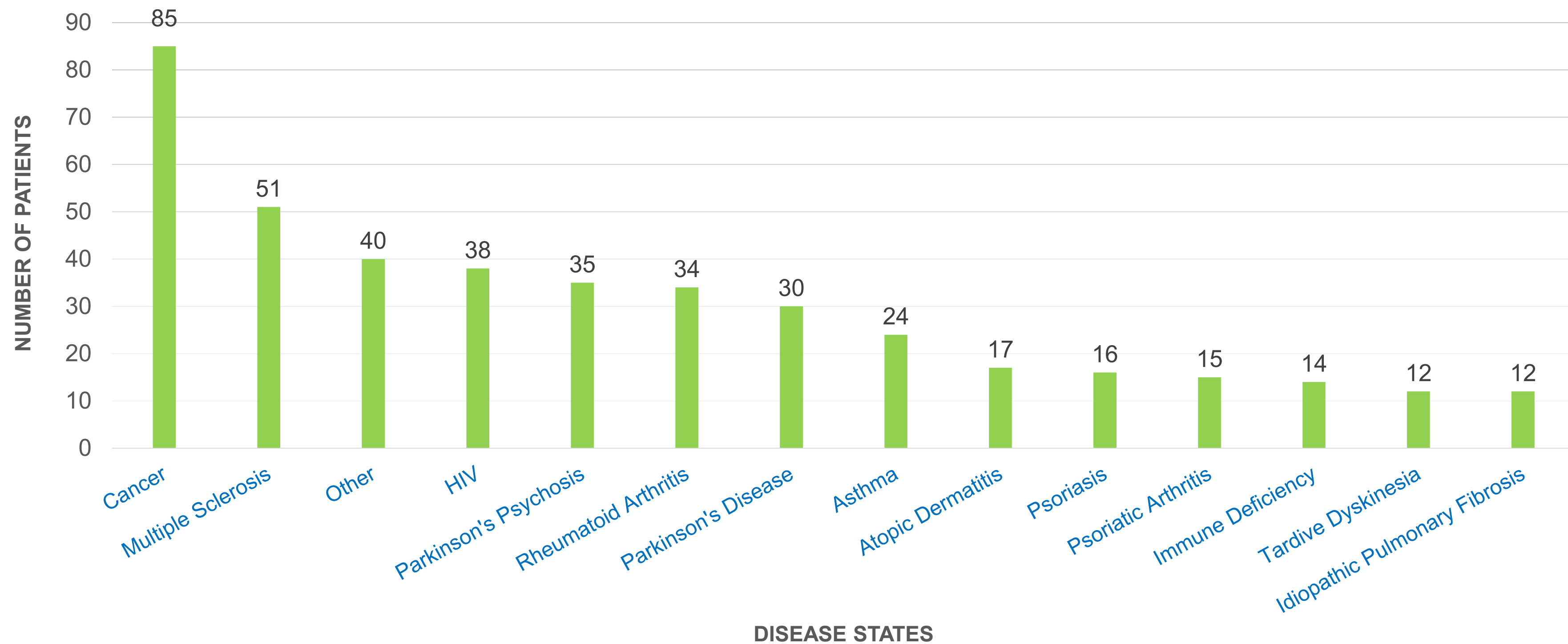
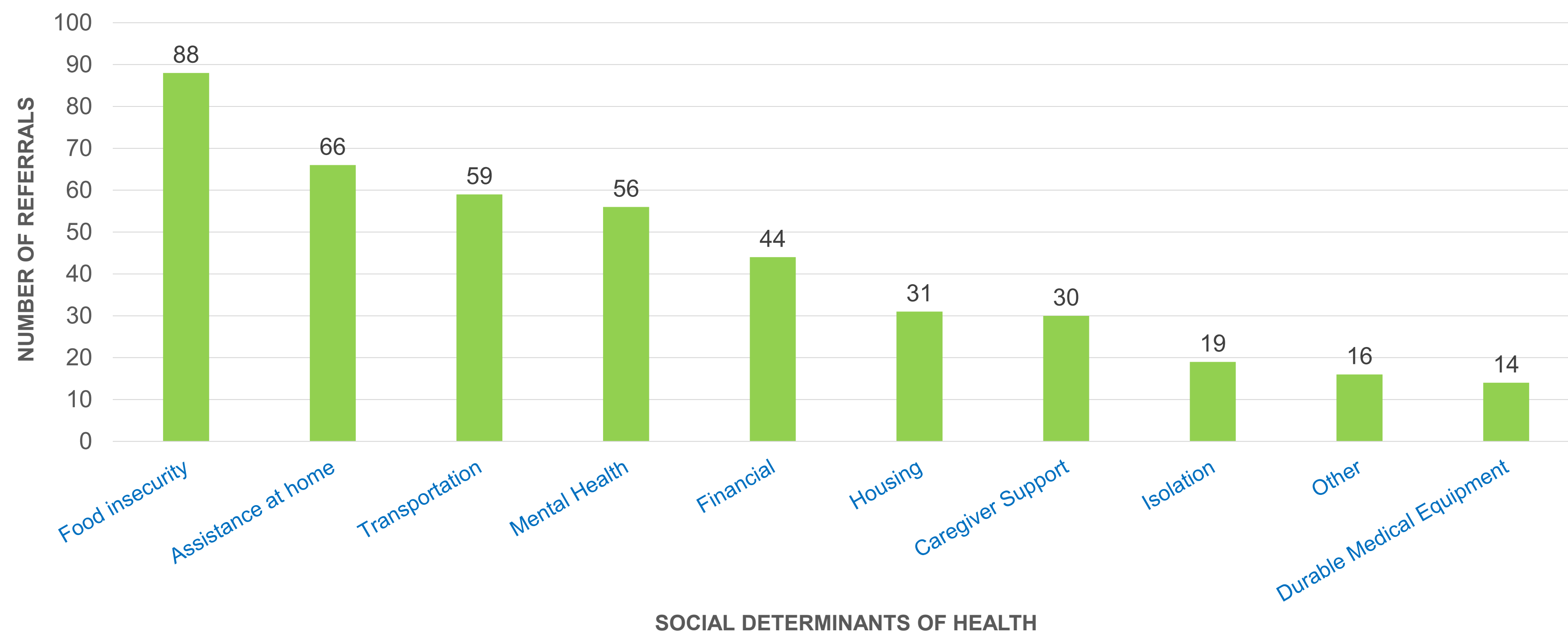


Figure 2. Primary Reasons for Referrals to Social Work Support



Evaluation

- From January 2024 to December 2024, 316 unique cases were referred to the LSW, totaling 423 identified SDOH needing intervention.
- The most prevalent SDOH cited were food insecurity (20.8%), assistance at home (15.6%), and transportation (13.9%).
- The three most common disease states—cancer, multiple sclerosis (MS), and HIV—exhibited similar SDOH trends in referrals. Specifically, 24% of cancer referrals were for food insecurity, 16% for mental health, and 12% for transportation or assistance at home. For patients with MS, 25% of referrals were for assistance at home, while 18% were for food insecurity or transportation. For HIV patients, 29% were referred due to food insecurity, 26% for mental health issues, and 16% for isolation.

Conclusions

- Incorporating an LSW within a specialty pharmacy setting extended patient support beyond traditional side effect management and medication adherence strategies.
- For high-need patient groups, such as those with cancer and MS, proactive support addressing food insecurity, transportation, and home assistance could significantly enhance patient care and quality of life

Future Research

- Next steps include evaluation of post-intervention results, such as resolution or improvement of social health need, of the LSW program at CWSP.
- Access to a social worker has been associated with improved adherence and increased symptom-free days in asthma patients; however, these outcomes have not been evaluated within specialty pharmacy populations.³
- Caregivers significantly impact patient quality of life but are at risk for burnout and depression. Support systems for caregivers have demonstrated benefits for both patients and caregivers.⁴ Further research in the specialty pharmacy setting may inform future expansion of social work programs.

References

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